

American Music Legend Quincy Jones Dies at 91

One of the biggest names in America's music industry – Quincy Jones – has died at the age of 91. A family statement said Jones passed away Sunday night surrounded by family members at his home in the Bel Air neighborhood of Los Angeles.

Jones is known for working with many top names in the music industry, including superstars Michael Jackson, Frank Sinatra and Ray Charles. Throughout his 65-year career, he worked with hundreds of other music artists.

Jones' publicist Arnold Robinson said in a statement, "Tonight, with full but broken hearts, we must share the news of our father and brother Quincy Jones' passing." It added, "And although this is an incredible loss for our family, we celebrate the great life that he lived and know there will never be another like him."

Born in Chicago in 1933, Jones said an early music influence was the hymns his mother used to sing around the house. Early on, he played music, the trumpet, and led others in band music.

FILE - Michael Jackson, left, holds eight awards as he poses with Quincy Jones at the Grammy Awards in Los Angeles, Feb. 28, 1984. Quincy Jones died at age 91. (AP Photo/Doug Pizac, File)

As a very young man, Jones used to run with gangs on the South Side of Chicago. But he later rose to the top of show business, becoming one of the first Black business leaders in Hollywood. Later, he established himself as a major composer and producer.

Jones shaped recordings by jazz greats such as Miles Davis and produced hits for Sinatra and Ella Fitzgerald. And he helped organize the 1985 money-raising event for Africa that resulted in the song We Are the World. The song went on to become one of the biggest hits of its time.

Jones composed music for *Roots* and *In the Heat of the Night*. He also organized President Bill Clinton's first inaugural celebration in 1993. Jones also wrote several movie scores and co-produced the film *The Color Purple*. In addition, he co-produced the highly successful 1990s television show *The Fresh Prince of Bel-Air*, which launched the career of Will Smith.

FILE - President Barack Obama presents a 2010 National Medal of Arts to musician and record producer Quincy Jones, Wednesday, March 2, 2011, during a ceremony in the East Room of the White House in Washington. (AP Photo/Pablo Martinez Monsivais, File)

Jones's work with superstar Michael Jackson still represents one of his most lasting successes. He and Jackson made three wildly popular albums: *Off the Wall* in 1979, *Thriller* in 1982, and *Bad* in 1987.

Thriller sold more than 20 million copies in 1983 alone. It helped Jackson become the first major Black artist to have a video played on MTV and influenced countless other performers. Jones later explained, “Michael had the look and the voice, and I had every sound you can think of.”

Jones was known for keeping company with presidents and foreign leaders, movie stars and musicians, philanthropists and business leaders. His circle of friends included some of the most famous people of the 20th century, including artist Pablo Picasso, Pope John Paul II and Nelson Mandela.

FILE - Quincy Jones cradles his Grammy awards including the album of the year award, for his eclectic album "Back on the Block" during the 33rd annual Grammy Awards, on Feb. 20, 1991. (AP Photo/Susan Ragan, File)

The list of Jones’ honors and awards fills 18 pages in his 2001 autobiography Q. The book made him a best-selling writer. He won a total of 27 Grammy Awards, as well as two honorary Academy Awards and an Emmy for the television series Roots.

Jones also received France's Legion d'Honneur, the Rudolph Valentino Award from the Republic of Italy and a Kennedy Center honor for his influence over American culture. He was the subject of a 1990 documentary called "Listen Up: The Lives of Quincy Jones," as well as the 2018 film Quincy, directed by his daughter, Rashida Jones.

I’m Bryan Lynn.

The Associated Press, Reuters and VOA News reported on this story. Bryan Lynn adapted the reports for VOA Learning English.

Vocabulary

hymn - n. เพลงสวดสรรเสริญพระเจ้า (โดยเฉพาะในศาสนาคริสต์)

gang - n. แก๊ง, กลุ่มคนร้าย, กลุ่มอันธพาล

composer - n. นักประพันธ์เพลง, คีตกวี

score - n. โน้ตเพลง, แผ่นเพลง (ใช้กับเพลงประกอบภาพยนตร์หรือละคร)

philanthropist - n. ผู้ใจบุญ, ผู้ที่บริจาคเงินหรือความช่วยเหลือแก่ผู้ที่ต้องการ

Reading Comprehension Quiz

1. What was Quincy Jones's age at the time of his death?

A. 65

B. 91

C. 87

D. 93

2. Which of the following artists is NOT mentioned as someone Quincy Jones worked with in his career?

A. Michael Jackson

B. Frank Sinatra

C. Ray Charles

D. Whitney Houston

3. What sentiment did Quincy Jones's publicist, Arnold Robinson, primarily express regarding Jones's passing?

A. A deep sense of relief after a long illness.

B. Profound sorrow mixed with a celebration of his impactful life.

C. D. Surprise at the suddenness of his death.

D. Focus on the financial legacy Jones left behind.

4. What was an early musical influence for Quincy Jones during his childhood?

A. Jazz clubs in Chicago.

B. Classical music lessons.

C. Hymns his mother sang.

D. Radio pop songs.

5. Before becoming a major composer and producer, what significant pioneering role did Quincy Jones achieve in Hollywood?

A. He became the first Black director to win an Academy Award.

B. He was recognized as one of the first Black business leaders.

C. He established the first Black-owned recording studio.

D. He founded a prominent acting school for Black performers.

6. What major charitable musical event did Quincy Jones help organize in 1985?

A. Live Aid

B. Farm Aid

C. We Are the World

D. Band Aid

7. Which television show, co-produced by Quincy Jones, launched the career of Will Smith?

A. Roots

- B. The Color Purple
- C. In the Heat of the Night
- D. The Fresh Prince of Bel-Air

8. What does the article identify as one of Quincy Jones's most lasting successes?

- A. His work on movie scores like "Roots".
- B. His collaborations with jazz greats like Miles Davis.
- C. His work with superstar Michael Jackson.
- D. Organizing President Clinton's inaugural celebration.

9. What notable achievement related to "Thriller" is mentioned in the article regarding Michael Jackson?

- A. It won the most Grammy Awards in history.
- B. It was the first album to sell over 100 million copies.
- C. It helped Jackson become the first major Black artist with an MTV video.
- D. It broke records for being written and produced by a single artist.

10. Quincy Jones was known for associating with a wide variety of influential individuals. Which group is NOT explicitly mentioned as part of his social circle?

- A. Presidents and foreign leaders
- B. Scientists and inventors
- C. Movie stars and musicians
- D. Philanthropists and business leaders

11. Which of these historical figures was listed among Quincy Jones's circle of friends?

- A. Albert Einstein
- B. Pablo Picasso
- C. Queen Elizabeth II
- D. Martin Luther King Jr.

12. What is the title of Quincy Jones's 2001 autobiography?

- A. The Life of Q
- B. Q
- C. Thriller: My Story
- D. Listen Up

13. How many Grammy Awards did Quincy Jones win in total?

- A. 18
- B. 27
- C. 33
- D. 65

14. Which international honor did Quincy Jones receive from France?

- A. The Rudolph Valentino Award
- B. The Legion d'Honneur
- C. The Kennedy Center Honor
- D. The Golden Globe Award

15. Who directed the 2018 film "Quincy" about Quincy Jones's life?

- A. Will Smith
- B. Michael Jackson
- C. Rashida Jones
- D. Bryan Lynn